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The Era of Digital Transition in the Prism of the Existential Threat of Job Loss: Corporate Social Responsibility

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Abstract: This article explores the question of the rate of digital progress in the context of the labour market. Specific features of the current situation are discussed: the temporality of socio-technological transformations, which is becoming less and less compatible with the harmonious development of man and society; the pace at which machines acquire intelligence; the total devaluation of mental labour; the unresolved issue of the role of man in the world of intelligent machines; and the criticality of the problem of the labour market due to its global nature, social significance and the rate of socio-technological changes. It is emphasised that these circumstances, already in the short term, threaten the sustainable development of global society, whose reactions to the transformation of technological and socio-economic infrastructure are significantly lagging behind. It is concluded that there is an urgent need to strengthen social responsibility, determined by the new ethics of relations between humans and machines with AI, supplemented by the primacy of the dignity of the social role of humans. The authors point out the urgent need to revise ideas about work as the main purpose of a person and about realisation in the profession as the main factor that determines the self-esteem of an individual and his social status.

Keywords: digital transit; sustainable development; labour market; professional employment; pace of development; artificial intelligence (AI); ChatGPT; corporate social responsibility

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1. Introduction

Over the past few decades, all levels of modern life, from global politics to everyday life, have undergone dramatic changes [1]. In this new reality, the explosive growth in the rate of change caused by the breakthrough development of digital technologies is of decisive importance. Due to the qualitative leap in the pace of development, fundamental changes are occurring in real time, creating both unprecedented opportunities and problems that humanity has never encountered in its history. At the same time, for the first time in human history, the pace of scientific and technological development is in radical conflict with the harmonious development of man and society, calling into question sustainable development, especially in terms of the development of the labour sphere. This is especially important due to the fact that one of the markers determining the balance of the economy and social life is the availability of jobs, which is defined in the goals and objectives of sustainable development [2].

The breakthroughs in the development of artificial intelligence (AI) and its rapid spread and application in various spheres [3–5] give special relevance to this transformational process. GAI burst into the mainstream in its incarnation in the form of ChatGPT. Since then, GAI has been presented as a transformational force, transforming everything on its own, albeit short, developmental path.

One of the most important life-forming spheres undergoing transformation in the course of the rapid development of information and communication technologies, far from the ontological space in which mankind has spent its entire historical life, leading a predominantly traditional way of life, is the sphere of labour. The emergence of ChatGPT

almost immediately caused a wide resonance, especially due to its potentially dangerous impact on the world of work [6]. The reason for this is the rapidity of the advent of the digital economy due to the inherent temporality of digital technologies, which has led to a huge increase in capitalisation with minimal resource inputs and, thanks to this, radically transformed the infrastructure of the labour economy, completely displacing people from employment.

The topic of the coming impact of digital technologies on the labour market is one of the most topical in recent years; it is at the forefront of relevance, has been considered from different perspectives and with different conclusions [7], and has been actualised, including in interdisciplinary scientific research [8–10].

Certainly, this topic is not new and is revealed with varying degrees of depth at each turn of scientific and technological progress [11], especially when the achievements of progress destroy the balance of efficiency of human labour in relation to machine labour [12].

This topic has been exacerbated by the emergence and unprecedented rapid development of generative artificial intelligence (GAI) and its application in all domains. The launch of OpenAI's ChatGPT in late 2022 was an important milestone in the field of artificial intelligence, as its ability to generate coherent, human-like text on a wide range of topics [5] initiated a discussion among researchers on how generative artificial intelligence can be integrated into the workplace. Given the fact that generative artificial intelligence displays a high degree of task accuracy [13], ease of implementation [14], and excels where there is a significant amount of repetitive work, it is a prime candidate for the application of new AI technologies [15]. Many research institutes are certainly working in this direction. Therefore, AI ethics occupies a crucial place in the research of scientists [16–19] and research teams [20–24].

However, in the light of such a rapid development of GAI in the context of its comprehensive penetration into all spheres of human and social life without exception, and, in particular, into the sphere of labour, which is so important for people, the question of social responsibility arises.

The phrase "social responsibility" should penetrate more and more deeply into our everyday life context, because values and morality are based on the principles of social responsibility [25]. The social responsibility of the state is directly related to the goals of sustainable development (which, of course, includes care for human beings) [2,26]. That is why all decisions are manifested in the system of measures implemented by the state, aimed at improving the quality of life of both different social groups and each individual.

This is where the lagoons in the field of research that address the question of the relationship between the development of AI, its impact on labour and the social responsibility of corporations at every level considered in this context are located.

Despite the abundance of studies devoted to the impact of AI on the sphere of labour [10,27–31], as well as on social responsibility itself [32–34], it is worth noting the lack of reflection on the problem of job cuts in the light of the existential significance of human involvement in professional activity, as well as the social responsibility of different levels of management and decision-making in these transformational processes. The questions of human existence in a world where professional skills are not in demand, where the goal, due to which he/she builds his/her professional and, therefore, social existence, immediately loses its relevance, as well as the question about the ethics of social responsibility for the ongoing socio-economic transformations and the place of a person in the new paradigm, where it is difficult for him/her to find himself/herself and build his/her life path (and, therefore, the meaning of life), as everything he/she strives for is suddenly "removed" from the zone of his/her responsibility, remain unanswered.

Thus, the aim of this article is to explore the relationship between the use of artificial intelligence and job loss. At the same time, we would like to emphasise this relationship in the focus of existential challenges and, as a consequence, social responsibility.

Hence, the objectives of this article are as follows:

First, to conduct a comparative analysis in order to identify the peculiarities of job loss in our time in comparison to all situations which have occurred in human history—to analyse the historical evolution of the discussion on the place and role of man in the labour process in connection with the turns of scientific and technological progress and identify the distinctive features of the contemporary situation;

Second, to point out the new paradigmatic changes that are taking place due to the radical loss of the usual way of social identification through professional affiliation;

Third, to emphasise the need to strengthen the factor of social responsibility in the context of super-fast job losses and to stress the need for a new paradigmatic change in the way of social identification through professional belonging;

Fourth, explain some of the possible directions of socio-economic regulation aimed at mitigating the social tensions associated with the possible drastic loss of the vast majority of jobs.

This article makes some contributions to this field.

First, it provides an overview of the polar views on the impact of scientific and technological progress in the digital age on the world of work (Section 2).

Secondly, a comparative analysis is carried out in order to identify the peculiarities of job losses in our time, in contrast to all the processes of transformation of the labour sphere due to scientific and technological progress that have taken place in human history. For this purpose, we analyse the historical evolution of the debate on the place and role of the human being in the labour process in connection with the turns of scientific and technological progress (Results Section 4.1), and we also explicate the distinctive features of the contemporary situation related to the orientation of scientific and technological progress towards the development of digital technologies (Results Section 4.2). It is shown that these features are manifested: (first) in the qualitative leap of socio-technological transformations, when multiple disappearances of professional strata occur before the eyes of one generation (Section 4.2.1); (second) in the shift of the place of technology in the labour process from an assistant and performer of heavy routine work to its mastery of superintellectual activity, as a result of which (third) man loses his dominant and predominant position of the owner of intellect (Section 4.2.2); (fourth) in the breadth, globality and depth of its reach (Section 4.2.3), and finally, (fifth) in this digital transformation, as robots encroach on human pleasure labour (Section 4.3).

Thirdly, by critically analysing the new challenges, existential implications are identified (Section 4.4.1). It concludes that there is an urgent need to address the ethics of social responsibility (Section 4.4.2), and outlines and delineates areas of social responsibility in the age of digital transit (Section 4.4.3).

2. Literature Review

Analysing research on the topic of interest, we came across several different ideas. Here, we categorise these ideas, highlighting on the one hand their different poles (optimistic and pessimistic scenarios for the development of AI and its impact on the workplace). On the other hand, since in light of such a rapid development of digital technologies there is almost always the question of the need for humans to catch up with these technologies in order to utilise them, we have included the often-discussed scenario of continuous learning.

1—Optimistic scenario. The development of artificial intelligence is positively associated with job losses. New opportunities are expected to emerge due to digitalisation. The number of jobs will increase.

Some authors, while pointing out the difficulties encountered with the advent of digitalisation, still arrive at a positive/optimistic scenario. Thus, a study by Willem Pieter de Groene, Carolien Lenaerts, Romain Bosc and Félix Pacquier, conducted for the European Economic and Social Committee at the interface of social sciences, concludes that digitalisation is expected to both destroy and create jobs, opening up new opportunities in the development of the labour market [35]. Some specific questions regarding its impact on

the labour market are raised by Degrise Christophe, also arriving at a possible optimistic scenario of new opportunities opened up by the Fourth Industrial Revolution [36].

Research in European countries shows that the number of jobs requiring people with higher education, such as managers, engineers and health workers, continues to grow [37]. There is also an increase in the "number of low-educated jobs in the service sector, such as salespeople, which are non-standard and difficult to replace with automation" [38]. Among the problems imposed by digitalisation on the labour market, the same imposition of the inclusion of lifelong learning in its paradigm is explicated [39]. Thus, some authors show that the modern university is a complex, at the same time sometimes conservative, but fragile system [40] and, as a result, external challenges will necessarily lead to internal changes [41], requiring it to comply and correlate with dominant trends, concepts, values and ideas [40].

During the pandemic, a global educational paradigm shift occurred [42]. A widespread consequence was the global engagement in online education [43]. Virtual education, which has become increasingly relevant in recent years [44], has nevertheless not completely displaced the classical education system [45]. On the contrary, it has demonstrated all its advantages [46]. Nevertheless, in the postpandemic period, which is now considered as a moment of forced digitalisation [42], there have been radical changes both in the use of new tools in the learning process [47] and in the new requirements for teachers [48].

Among the optimists, the "Positive scenario of lifelong learning" stands out. According to the proponents of this idea, digitalisation and the development of artificial intelligence lead to a redistribution of jobs and demand for new skills. Therefore, corporate social responsibility is about enhancing the abilities and competences of employees.

At the same time, it is important to note that the temporality of technology development leads to the fact that in a few years it becomes clear that the human being cannot keep up with the super-fast development of information technology [1], so the human being is offered to learn and learn a lot [49]. In this regard, lifelong learning became one of the key agenda items in the World Development Report 2019 of the World Bank Group [27]. In 2017, the World Economic Forum published a report on accelerating re-learning for the Fourth Industrial Revolution, highlighting that more than a quarter of workers have a mismatch between their current skills and the skills needed for their jobs [28]. UNESCO is creating a global network of lifelong learning cities, so-called learning cities [50], in an attempt to find the right mix of resources, institutional structures, modern technologies and cosmopolitan values to serve as incubators and drivers for 21st century knowledge societies [50–53]. Access to quality education for all humanity is at the heart of the Sustainable Development Goals and targets [2].

2—Pessimistic scenario. The use of artificial intelligence will lead to the complete replacement of humans in almost all spheres of labour. As a result of digitalisation, a huge number of jobs will be washed out of the labour niche.

On the other side of the scale is the claim that a huge number of jobs will be washed out of the labour niche, that the use of artificial intelligence is positively associated with job loss. There are now many studies proving this [54,55]. The study we have already mentioned [38], despite positively valuing jobs for people with higher education and specialised skills, nevertheless shows that "the number of jobs with secondary education (clerks, mechanics, assemblers) is decreasing" [38].

Those at the forefront of technology development are not so optimistic. Their least painful warning is that all the professions we are preparing students for today will be gone by the time they graduate from high school. Research leaders such as Ilon Musk, Bill Gates and Jack Ma have made even more alarming suggestions that artificial intelligence is likely to completely displace humans from the world of work [56–58]. Researchers at Boston University have estimated that installing each additional industrial robot fires three to six workers [59].

The McKinsey Global Institute notes that by 2030, automation will make 400 million people redundant—that is 15% of all jobs in the world [60]. Moreover, after being forced

to experiment with widespread global unemployment because of COVID-19 [42], "this sounds even more ominous" [60]. They predict that in the very near future, jobs in banking and insurance companies, energy and mining will be cut by a third; manufacturing and retail will shed up to half of their jobs [60].

3—Social Responsibility Scenario. Mitigation of the shock from the total reduction of the labour market and strengthening of the direction of work on the ethics of artificial intelligence.

This means a sharp release from work of a huge number of the planet's population with the need for an instant restructuring of the paradigm of its existence and all the bases of life. However, under these conditions, huge efforts of states [61,62], corporations, research teams [20] and individual scientists [16–18,63–65] are directed to the development of the problem of AI ethics.

In this regard, it is necessary to refer to such an important concept as "social responsibility", which acquires special acuteness and significance in the conditions of unprecedented development of artificial intelligence and its total and global spread.

The social responsibility of the state is directly related to the concept of sustainable development. The UN in 2015 adopted a resolution proclaiming 17 Sustainable Development Goals, a significant part of which are aimed at solving social problems [26].

Social responsibility is an ethical principle, which is that in order to realise public duty in the decision-making process it is necessary to take into account not only the interests of individuals or organisations making these decisions, but also the interests, values and goals of broad social groups and society as a whole [32].

The main form of manifestation of social responsibility of any corporation (from the state, traditionally considered as a legislator of social responsibility [25], to the business community [66], scientific teams [33,34] and responsible persons [67]) is the social policy they build and implement [15]. Such decisions are manifested in a system of measures implemented by the state and all responsible corporations aimed at improving the quality of life, which certainly includes the possibility of finding a decent job for each person and the possibility of professional self-realisation.

3. Materials and Methods

The logic of this study is based on the cultural–historical concept, according to which the transformation of the human world is considered organically embedded in culture, whose mode of existence is the evolution of various forms of socio-historical activity [68,69]. In order to achieve the set goals in the analysis of scientific sources on the topic of the forthcoming impact of digital technologies on the labour market, we used the method of critical analysis [70], which includes the evaluation of various indicators and criteria. As criteria for selecting sources, we focused on opposing viewpoints on this impact. At one pole of views on the development of AI and its impact on the workplace, sources leaning towards the optimal scenario were selected. At the other pole, sources were selected that can be classified more as pessimistic views on the development of the situation.

Given the complexity of the problem, this study was conducted using comparative-historical analysis [71] and axiological methods [72] based on the relevant scientific literature.

This study did not require the use of experimental methods. We mainly used theoretical methods, which were based on the study of scientific articles on relevant sources, reports and reports of the expert community, as well as strategic government documents.

At the first stage of this study, we made a comparative analysis of the current job loss situation with previous eras, identifying the features. This was done on the basis of (first) a sociological and phenomenological analysis of the current situation. (Second) The interdisciplinary status of the research problem area required the use of a synthesis of methods to comprehensively analyse the current situation and construct alternative scenarios for the future under conditions of narrowing horizons caused by ultra-fast technological progress. (Third) The information obtained was subjected to a comparative analysis that identified the main problems and emphases in the topic under study. In the next stage of research, we explicated the new paradigmatic changes occurring due to the

radical loss of the traditional way of social identification through professional affiliation. The identified knowledge was comparatively analysed and critically evaluated in order to put it into context and a new theoretical framework.

In the interest of the research, we conduct a conceptual definition of the place of the individual in the system of labour relations in the digital economy, using the method of scientific abstraction. The individual with his or her abilities and needs is seen as both a goal and an important resource.

Here, we relied on the results of the application of the qualitative method in the work with his patients by Viktor Frankl (the founder of the method of existential psychoanalysis), who, in the course of many years of research, revealed the decisive influence of involvement in the labour process on finding the meaning of life [73].

As a result, on the basis of socio-philosophical comprehension of the value parameter of human identification through his/her professional goal, we analyse the adoption of social responsibility (of the state, social institutions of upbringing and education, various corporations and expert organisations, communities) as a fundamental basis for the construction of man–machine relations in the sphere of work. On this basis, we show the possible directions of social responsibility in the era of digital transit.

4. Results and Discussion

Specifics of the contemporary situation in a comparative analysis of historical retrospective in connection with the disappearance of jobs.

The aim of our article was to explore the relationship between the use of artificial intelligence and job loss in the focus of existential challenges and, consequently, social responsibility. Therefore, in order to achieve this goal, we set several objectives, which were fulfilled. The results are described below.

A comparative analysis was carried out in order to identify the peculiarities of job loss in our time in comparison with all situations that have occurred in human history (Sections 4.1 and 4.2); the historical evolution of the discourse on the place and role of the individual in the labour process in connection with the turns of scientific and technological progress was analysed (Section 4.1). The distinctive features of the modern situation are revealed and new paradigm changes are outlined, which occur due to the radical loss of the usual way of social identification through professional affiliation (Sections 4.2, 4.2.1–4.2.4, 4.3, 4.4 and 4.4.1). The necessity of strengthening the factor of social responsibility in connection with the super-fast reduction of jobs is emphasised (Section 4.4.2); some possible directions of socio-economic regulation aimed at mitigating social tension associated with the possible sharp loss of the overwhelming majority of jobs are explicated (Section 4.4.3).

4.1. Historical Retrospective

In the intellectual world, the first steps of the Industrial Revolution already sparked heated debates about the place and role of human beings in this industrialised world and how they were affected by the advent of such machines, factories and steamships [74,75]. Over time, physical labour was largely displaced by mechanical machines and by the second half of the 20th century, human employment was reallocated to the service sector or the "tertiary sector" as J.-M. Ferri calls it, encompassing all public and private services, from beauty salons to public education and health care, including commerce and public transport [76].

The Third Industrial Revolution and the emergence of computer technology set a new vector for solving this problem. There was a tendency to redistribute jobs in favour of professions related to the information sphere. Actually, the beginning of the information society—its "project" period is considered to be the statistical report, which appeared in the late 50s of the last century in the U.S. Department of Commerce, showed that for the first time in history the number of workers exceeded the number of production workers.

The emergence of computers in the middle of the twentieth century caused a discussion about the special role of intelligent machines, their possible competition with humans, and the problems of the future caused by this direction of technological development (N. Wiener [77], J. Licklider [78]).

The second half of the twentieth century saw a surge of interest in understanding the observed transformation of society due to the progress of info-communications (in particular, printing, television and the first computers). Detailed analyses of these phenomena are contained in the works of J. Fourastié, N. Wiener, D. Bell, M. Heidegger, M. Castells, K. Jaspers, E. Toffler, M. McLuhan, N. Luhmann, J. Habermas and others [79–83]. At the same time, a sceptical attitude to the "cybernetic revolution" appeared, which, according to D. Bell, turned out to be "illusory" [84].

Later, this issue was also addressed by E. Toffler, D. Bell and D. Naisbitt [84–86]. Naisbitt, for example, writes that in 1950 only 17% of Americans worked in the field of information. Now, 65% of all employees work with information—programmers, teachers, clerks, secretaries, accountants, stockbrokers, insurance agents, officials, lawyers, bankers and engineers. In addition, many other workers in manufacturing companies also work with information. Most Americans spend their time creating, processing and disseminating information. For example, employees of banks, stock markets and insurance companies are busy working with information [86].

As we can see, until recently, the problem of jobs was relevant and was historically somehow solved over time. However, the formation of the digital civilisation has brought its unique specifics to this issue. Let us analyse them.

4.2. Distinctive Features of the Current Situation

4.2.1. Pace—Disappearance of Professional Strata before the Eyes of a Generation

In the history of technological development, we certainly find examples of the disappearance of professional layers. A rather striking well-known example is the Luddite rebellion. However, such stories concerned individual professional layers in rather localised areas. In the world space of that time, such changes were much slower. One change could take place over many generations, so they were almost imperceptible.

That is, progress and the transformations of professional spheres caused by it took place in all times, but the development of civilisation was so slow that during the lifetime of one generation the changes were almost imperceptible. The speed of change was incomparable to the speed of the processes that began at the moment of industrialisation, when the picture of professional activity began to change rapidly.

The resulting qualitative leap in the pace of development leads to the fact that for the first time in the history of mankind there were fundamental transformations of technological and revolutionary nature in the socio-economic environment, having an immediate impact on humanity as a whole, which began to occur repeatedly during one human life [3].

The specificity of the temporality of the development of the digital world leads to the fact that the transformation of the world of work with a radical reduction of huge professional niches begins to occur non-stop before the eyes of one generation. At the same time, such a development even at the beginning of the 21st century seemed quite unbelievable. Thus, in 2001, Michael Porter in his then still controversial article "Strategy and the Internet" [87] recorded new trends in the labour market. Ref. [87] recorded new trends in the relationship between seller and buyer. The article provoked opposition because it stated that the need for conventional salespeople was disappearing and being replaced by seller–buyer relationships in the Internet space. This was indeed hard to believe. Porter later develops this theme in terms of competition in a new marketplace built using the power of the World Wide Web. In his view, new technologies accelerate the evolution of the relationship between seller and buyer, leading to significant changes in many areas [88]. However, this confluence of circumstances was predicted by N. Wiener, who noted that "the automaton... is the exact economic equivalent of slave labour. Any labour force competing with slave labour must accept the economic conditions of slave

labour. It is quite clear that this will create a situation of unemployment compared to which the present recession and even the depression of the thirties will seem a pleasant joke" [77].

If at the beginning of the XXI century such statements were controversial, today it is an obvious problem that is at the peak of its relevance. Discussions are conducted in a variety of directions. We hear them from the media and from discussions in expert communities. The impact of digital transformation on the workplace is at the centre of academic reflection and political debate around the world [8,89,90].

In 2012, CNN tried to find out which professions will become obsolete and which will reappear [29]. Later, in 2016, Microsoft published a list of popular professions by 2025 [91]. The World Economic Forum in Davos in 2016 was devoted to the problem of the loss of professions [61]. It has become evident that we are facing the risk of losing mass professions, such as professions in trade, transport, etc. Many researchers conclude that as a result of technological progress in industrialised countries [47], a large number of skilled professionals are emerging and unskilled labour will be released from the production process [92]. The real picture shows that as, within a generation, professions disappear, whole professional strata are washed out of the economy or undergo radical changes.

Changes in the labour market are not just a consequence of the leaching of occupations. The problem is a reduction in the total labour force in certain segments of the economy [93]. As we have shown above, these are drivers, security guards, factory workers, bank clerks, etc. This is a progressive movement that occurs throughout human history, but in the temporality of the digital age, the total volume of labour has decreased almost simultaneously and at a global level.

4.2.2. AI Development—Automation—Automation—AI—Super AI

The machine has ceased to be a mere helper performing only the functions of a physical apparatus. It has acquired intelligence with a tendency towards super intelligence. Until now, such an idea existed in the form of a myth, embodied, for example, in the image of the animated clay giant Golem, which, according to the idea of the creators, was supposed to meet the needs of man, because since ancient times people dreamed of a helper who could work hard. However, Golem, gradually gaining experience, began to assert his will, becoming dangerous to man himself [94].

We find a philosophical vision of this problem in the work of American scientist Joseph Licklider "Symbiosis of Man and Computer in One Book: Transactions on the Human Factor in Electronics" [78], in which he argues that the Human Factor in Electronics is the most important factor in the development of a computer and that the function of the machine cannot be a point of reference—the computer must always be a human assistant. In this sense, the machine is seen as a helpless helper fulfilling the will of man.

Until recently, this idea was supported by the full conviction that the human mind is unquestionably superior to the capabilities of both the animal and artificial worlds, since the machine does everything by simply reciting pre-programmed programmes, and man acts incomprehensibly correctly since the spark of God is involved. Consequently, this meant a limitless field of application for the human mind.

The seed of doubt was sown at the moment when the grandmaster, as a representative of the intellectual elite of mankind, lost to a computer in chess. The human priority was finally debunked by losing at go [95]. In this regard, a curious case is discussed. Thus, in 2016, a famous scientist stated that, unlike chess, the game of go requires intellectual understanding, and if a computer is ever able to play go, it will not happen within 100 years [96]. Man lost at go in a matter of days. Thus, with each passing moment, fewer and fewer humans are doing a better job than computers. The remaining share of labour is melting away before our eyes. With each passing moment, people are doing fewer and fewer things better than computers.

The situation changed dramatically right after the release of ChatGPT. Within months, Google laid off about 12,000 employees, mostly software engineers [97]. These were the most highly skilled and in-demand professionals. A similar situation occurred at

Amazon. In the same January 2023, 18,000 people were laid off at once. Then, in March of this year, another 9 thousand people were forced to stay without work [98]. In 2023, IBM explicitly stated that thousands of employees would be laid off as they would be replaced by artificial intelligence [13]. The wave of layoffs has not only affected seemingly measurable professions such as IT developers. Creative professions have also been affected. For example, in China in 2023, statistics show that the labour market for artists in the field of animation for computer games will shrink by 70% [4]. The next wave of protests affected the film industry. First, those who had devoted their lives to learning the language and writing subtitles went on strike. Then, the whole world learnt about the revolt of Hollywood actors against the use of artificial intelligence, which directly threatened their profession, and thus their fame, their finances and their future relevance in the acting profession [99]. What has happened even in the last year and a half can be talked about endlessly. It is now very difficult to name a field of endeavour that has not been affected by corruption due to the development of generative artificial intelligence.

Thus, the downsizing associated with the development of AI does not only affect areas of simple procedures that can be easily replaced by software. It is not a liberation from routine labour, but a complete liberation from labour. After all, modern machines are not just machines, they are carriers of artificial intelligence [100]. They are already capable of more than routine labour. They play chess, write poetry, perform operations. A possible decline is seen in professional niches that require higher intellectual ability, education and intuition, such as scientific research.

4.2.3. Labour Market Contraction Affects Humanity on a Global Scale

In the modern situation, the problem of labour market contraction becomes socially significant not only for some individual part of the population, but also relevant at the mass level, because at the moment almost all of humanity is involved in labour activity.

This has been facilitated, firstly, by the absence of a global war in which a huge part of the male population could realise itself. Consequently, all men who had previously served in the army were involved in work, employed. Secondly, the twentieth century, especially its second half, was marked by gender equality and the emancipation of women, who now took a significant part in the labour process.

This was facilitated, firstly, by the absence of a global war in which a huge part of the male population could realise themselves. Accordingly, all men who had previously served in the army were called up and employed. Secondly, the 20th century, especially its second half, was marked by gender equality and the emancipation of women, who are now significantly involved in the labour process.

Thus, in the conditions of digital civilisation, when the technological infrastructure undergoes radical changes almost simultaneously, covering all continents, transformations in the sphere of labour affect not one layer in one local place, but all of humanity at the global level. At the same time, if today almost 100 percent inclusiveness still remains, then tomorrow, with the current development of the situation, it may be exclusivity, close to the same 100 percent.

4.2.4. Robots Will Do Work That Is Pleasant for a Person

Heavy physical labour has been significantly reduced by now (with the exception of some professional niches: cleaners, builders, farmers, who still work, albeit with the help of technology); even skilled labour has been reduced to a minimum. The conveyor has also been displaced, but routine intellectual labour still remains and occupies a huge part of all labour. This is the so-called "white collar" niche, which has been partially occupied by former workers. We find an understanding of this fact in the works of E. Toffler, M. Castells, D. Bell and others [84,101]. However, even this clean and relatively pleasant work is already being mastered by machines. The modern machine is invading even the segment of very complex routine work. Paradoxically, these can be people of the highest qualification, highly intelligent, solving specific problems (including scientific ones, for

example, in the field of natural science: physics, chemistry, biology). This is a huge part of humanity, which, with all due respect and reverence to them, has neither the ability nor the inclination for creative activity. Such people will remain without work. At the same time, people capable of performing non-standard work are a minority. At the same time, people love such work and are proud of their position. In the modern civilised world, there are already many people who are rich from birth, own estates and have decent savings. Having such freedom and, of course, education, they are hungry for work, look for it, even without pay, and extremely value the opportunity to come to work, do something, solve problems, because not only "monetary competition" motivates a person [102]. They go to work at the university, they value this place, having great ambitions. At the same time, their level of well-being can be several orders of magnitude higher than that of any worker, but they are dependent—they humanly want recognition, self-realisation and see this in their realisation in a profession that depends on them, and not on their money. For such people, work is connected with life—this is such an ambiguous life with multidirectional emotions: ups, downs, breakdowns, nervous breakdowns and joys, but he does not want the quiet life that is provided to him. This attitude to work is typical. In addition, and this is perhaps the determining factor: a profession is identification, position and respect in society. In "Arizona Dream", the main character talked about his father, who worked as a small-time policeman and valued his work very much. The father taught his son that work is like a hat. When you have it on your head, you feel good, and when you do not have a hat, you feel like a complete idiot. The same thing happens without work. If you have a job, you are respected (you have some social status), if you do not have a job, you do not know who you are.

4.3. Results of the Analysis of Specific New Challenges of the Digital Transit Era Regarding the Place of a Person in the Labour Market

Thus, rethinking the problem of relations in the human–machine system at the current stage of scientific and technological progress shows that the already achieved level of development of digital technologies turns the question of the place of technology in human life into the problem of determining the role of a person in the modern world of intelligent machines. Historically, one of the most important achievements of scientific and technological progress was the liberation of mankind from hard, harmful physical labour. The emergence of intelligent machines can free a person even from (so desired) mental labour, in which a modern person finds not only satisfaction of the natural need for labour, but also self-realisation, socialisation, structuring of life and, in many cases, the meaning of life itself.

The basis for this conclusion is the progressive devaluation and displacement of mental labour in a digital society, as well as the expectation of a sharp increase in this trend with the development of artificial intelligence. The main problem here is the new pace of technological development and, as a consequence, socio-technological transformations. Robot labour can provide material well-being for society, but in the context of the temporality of the digital world, the prospect of a sharp reduction in the need for human labour leads to the need to revise generally accepted ideas, especially ideas about the future that determine the construction of the life trajectory of any responsible person or corporation.

4.4. Man in the New World

4.4.1. Existential Threat

Here, an open question is alarming: in history, freeing humanity from heavy, harmful physical labour was considered a magnanimous mission of scientific and technological progress. However, almost before our eyes, an evolving intelligent machine has suddenly invaded all working niches. Equipped with artificial, and now super-artificial intelligence, it is more efficient than people in almost everything. The area in which man surpasses machines is shrinking with each passing moment. If earlier a machine, shouldering heavy, hated physical labour, freed man from the need to use his animal essence in the labour

process, today it takes away from man easy, pleasant and desired work, in which man finds motivation, socialisation, realisation, structuring of life and pleasure in general. Thus, man is deprived of an understandable opportunity to manifest his human essence. This situation challenges the existing paradigm of the usual basic ideas about how to live in this world. Optimistic humanity will answer—enjoy. Perhaps life will turn out quite positively in terms of material well-being and the physical condition of people. However, what should a person do in this situation? For a person, only enjoying means living an animal life. On the one hand, this does not contradict human nature and corresponds to the way of life in paradise described in the Bible; on the other hand, human nature requires competition, work. Perhaps this is why people do not want to live in paradise. In the science fiction novel by H. G. Wells "The Time Machine", we find a picture of a carefree life where people sing and dance [103]. This is how a society of people freed from the need to work was imagined. However, the English economist J. M. Keynes in his work comes to the conclusion that, despite the fact that it is generally believed that in a society of abundance everyone will dance and sing psalms, "man needs work" [104]. The famous psychologist Viktor Frankl, the founder of the existential psychoanalysis method—logotherapy, comes to a similar conclusion in his practice. His professional experience shows that without work a person feels emptiness, a lack of meaning in life [73]. Frankl himself believed that "a person completely mistakenly identifies his professional calling with the life task for which he is called into this world" [73]. Nevertheless, professional experience convinces Frankl that a person's life "is filled with meaning through work", and unemployment becomes "a breeding ground for the spread of neuroses" [73].

In considering the potential of the workforce in the mid-20th century, N. Wiener, who stood at the origins of the computer age, points out that "the machine... is the exact economic equivalent of slave labour. Any workforce competing with slave labour must provide the economic conditions for slave labour. It is clear that this will create a situation of unemployment in comparison with which the recession and even the depression of the thirties will seem like a pleasant joke" [77]. He doubts that "it would be good for humanity if machines were freed from the need to do dirty and unpleasant work" [77]. What can be said if a modern machine frees it from clean, noble and pleasant work? It should be noted that the socio-economic paradigm was formed in the course of the historical development of humanity. The industrial era left a special mark, finally forming the idea of a person's purpose (in the narrow sense, as understood by the majority of the population), which has become traditional today, consisting in the need to work, grow professionally and, as a result, acquire social status through a profession. Understanding work as one's purpose, self-realisation, and, consequently, as the goal and meaning of life is cultivated by all social institutions.

In the context of everything that is happening, when we are unable to predict the future, the question of a person's purpose naturally arises, which is especially relevant for a person of Western culture, striving to succeed in this world. His status is connected with how he made himself, how he succeeded in his work, in his career. This understanding created a core—a person knows his purpose by default (in the general sense), and, knowing it, he feels more comfortable, following the beaten path to a clear goal.

Understanding the need to work throughout life is nurtured by education. All stages of life: childhood, school, college—all these are stages of work. From childhood, a person is tuned in and prepared for the fact that he will work there, in work: in a career, in a salary, in a status—he will prove himself, show. This is what his parents expect from him. The purpose of life is largely built in accordance with this task. At the same time, there is evidence of this awareness: interest, aspiration, conscious choice. This has long been important for men, and has become important for women in many ways. There are other ways to achieve social recognition which are less common: social activities, helping those in need. However, they make sense only against the background of work. Work for many is a measure of self-identification, a sign of belonging to something greater, an opportunity to proudly declare their social status. Since in the near future only a few high-class, "special"

people will work, who will not be replaced by a robot or any program, self-identification, apparently, will simply follow the principle: do you work or not? Thus, the possibility of a one-time washout of the world of labour from the ontological field of human existence can lead to revolutionary transformations with all the ensuing changes in relation to the feeling of loss of the usual style and way of life. As a result, new trends are born, such as a decrease in motivation for learning and self-improvement, up to a complete change in lifestyle and behavioural stereotypes. This causes quite justified anxiety, generated by the uncertainty of the rapidly approaching future with an unresolved question about the place of man as a working professional in the world of intelligent machines. The civilisational scale of these transformations and trends becomes clear in the context of the key role that human involvement in professional employment has played in the history of mankind.

The consequence of such a speed of destruction of meanings is that a new meaning must be developed almost instantly—in the temporality of the digital world, which contradicts human nature (our internal temporality).

The situation of the transformation of the world of work described above, when almost all of humanity is involved in it, with an uncertain role of man in the world of intelligent machines, occurring in the specific temporality of the digital world, can be designated as an existential threat to the social organism, whose reactions to changes in the technological environment are significantly delayed. Accordingly, there is a need for a socio-philosophical understanding of these processes.

4.4.2. An Urgent Need for a New Ethic of Social Responsibility

In the last decade, the world has sounded the alarm about the rapid development of artificial intelligence. More and more countries are investing (money and effort) in an attempt to become the first in this race for super-strong AI. At the same time, scientists are concerned about the consequences that may arise in human society under these conditions. Research centres dealing with AI ethics are opening up everywhere [20–23]. The issue of machine ethics is undoubtedly important and is being addressed by a great number of the best minds [16–19], but we believe that the issue of human existence (social personality) is no less important, especially in connection with its existential nature in a world where "the use of artificial intelligence and robotics systems as more functional than traditional systems can potentially improve the quality of life of consumers" [96].

The pace at which the digitalisation of jobs is taking place as a result of the contraction of the labour market with the devaluation of the role of man in the labour process requires the state to assume responsibility in some areas in relation to man "working". In the conditions of the temporality of technological development of previous eras, the problem of employment was solved by the method of reactive response. The speed of modern socio-technological transformations requires active actions, for which we are completely unprepared.

Thus, the problem has matured, it corresponds to a new moment in the life of mankind and, as a result, should be on the agenda, at the forefront of research in social philosophy. This is why we consider it necessary to create an ethics of social responsibility that regulates the relationship of man with intelligent machines and under any conditions determines the primacy of the dignity of the social role of man.

4.4.3. Directions of Social Responsibility in the Era of Digital Transit

Let us outline some directions of social responsibility that we consider important in the era of digital transit.

1—Recognition of the impossibility of spontaneous harmonisation of the labour market.

Despite the challenges of modern times, humanity for the most part continues to exist in a sense of inertial stability, that the spontaneous harmonisation of the labour market, which has always occurred, will also occur in the conditions of digital civilisation. The inertial feeling of stability in the labour market is rooted in a variety of sources. Firstly,

based on history (and from the linear continuation of the historical course), and secondly, from various momentary interests, is proclaimed in every possible way by state heralds.

Indeed, based on the historical realities of the relationship between man and machine, we see that the problem of jobs has always been solved one way or another.

In fact, in the course of development on a historical time scale, such cases of the capture of jobs by technology looked like episodes that were always overcome—the loss of some working niches was compensated by the emergence of new ones [105]. At the same time, the introduction of new technologies into production led to the fact that labour productivity increased, the labour market was transformed, an new segments and niches emerged, resulting in a demand for an increasing number of workers.

The future is unpredictable, especially in the temporary conditions of the formation of a digital civilisation. However, if we remain within the framework of the historically and empirically manifested trend, then we can assume that everything will be harmonised in some natural way. The facts of history create a feeling that, despite the advent of a new reality, humanity will automatically develop some kind of solution; therefore, in this digital world, a person will still find a niche for the application of his profession and will be busy with the labour process and, perhaps, even working hands, which cannot be overlooked.

This feeling is invariably supported by the policies of many states. We are talking about raising the retirement age, inviting migrants, and persistently advertising for gig workers [30,106,107] with high qualifications—with skills that employers need here and now [108], and not with a general education.

A similar personnel policy is also carried out under the rule of technocrats. After all, in a spontaneous market economy, when everything is released to the market, to competition, as a result, everything is aimed at technical progress—preferably what is profitable here and now—in the current short moment. Although in the long term, as a rule, the involvement and use of new technologies in the labour process really did lead to overall success and prosperity.

However, today this version of spontaneous development is unacceptable, since it leads to absurdity.

Indeed, most likely, given the fact that robots (automatons, including those with AI and super-AI) are more efficient than people, under such a policy the value of human labour will inevitably depreciate in the near future, with a reasonable replacement for this not luxurious car. This means that the unrestrained formation of a digital civilisation and, as a consequence, the development of intelligent machines will lead to their total use in all professional niches, devaluing the social status of a person, and this is absurd. Thus, despite the historical experience of spontaneous harmonisation of human relations with technology, we come to the absurdity of a purely technocratic scenario of development, when intelligent machines displace a person in the labour market. Therefore, it is necessary to recognise the fact that spontaneous harmonisation of the labour market is unlikely, given the pace of development of technologies and socio-economic transformations corresponding to the formation of a digital civilisation. In this situation, the salvation scenario may be at least partially "humanistic", achievable through controlled harmonisation of the labour market. Regulatory policy takes time.

2—Providing people with work during the transition period.

Few people doubt that humanity is capable of finding adequate answers. However, the problem here is that in the conditions of the emerging digital reality, revolutionary changes are taking place, one of the main features of which is their inherent specific pace, when fundamental socio-technical transformations occur repeatedly during one human life; this does not allow postponing the decision to some distant future.

Klaus Schwab (Executive Chairman of the WEF) noted at the World Economic Forum 2020 that the emergence of the Internet in our lives is the reason for the creation of a "culture of emergency response" [31], but we assume that today the most important (one might even say essential) need is to solve the problem of the "blurring" of the meaning of life. Moreover, this is important not only for the future generations that Schwab speaks of, but

already for the generation living today. The speed with which the situation is developing allows us to assume that the problem will affect almost each of us. This is why the use of the so-called "dictatorship of urgency" is urgently needed. Thus, taking into account the importance of professional employment in the life of a modern person, as well as the complexity of accepting new conditions in which he will not work, and the time lag required for this, we believe that the regulation of this process will be humane.

In this sense, one of the tasks of the new ethics of social responsibility is to ensure employment and professional demand for a person. Such an approach is important, at least in the transitional period in which all of humanity finds itself, as part of the digital civilisation.

Potentially, this could be an artificial (legislative) solution to attract human labour, as well as various compensation mechanisms, which are considered, for example, by Vivarelli in his works [109]. Furthermore, as we see, there is movement in this direction.

3—Preparing a person for a sharp paradigm shift and a collision with an existential problem. Creating a paradigm of a "non-working" person.

Creating jobs or using various regulation methods is an extremely important step, but it is necessary in the transitional period. At the same time, one of the main tasks of the new ethics of social responsibility in the context of the temporality of socio-technical transformations in the digital age is understanding and accepting the situation, realising that in the era of such rapid development of intelligent machines, the probability of unemployment is extremely high. At least, this concerns employment in the modern sense, when work is provided by the employer in compliance with the established requirements that shape the working day and, as a result, a person's life. Ultimately, this understanding must be conveyed to the consciousness of each person. We want to say that humanity must be ready for this and thereby get rid of the illusion of the demand for their work. A person must understand this and prepare for a different future, perhaps a better one. Moreover, this must happen at a pace corresponding to the pace of digital development. Then, he will begin to build his life differently today. This is the new role of a social thinker.

4—Development of new meanings.

Thus, the sudden invasion of digital civilisation into our lives with the rapid devaluation of mental labour has raised the issue of the urgent need to revise the concept of labour as the main goal of a person and realisation in a profession as the basis for building a life trajectory. Therefore, we come to the need to revise the very foundations of understanding the meaning of human life, his motivation, including answers to questions about what it means to have a place in this life and not to live it in vain. This will express concern for the person himself, and this is necessary first of all for each individual. In all likelihood, the new reality requires a new person with a different average archetype, with a different set of basic attitudes, possibly with a different psychotype: more open and tolerant to change. This statement is not new, but understanding this fact in modern conditions has a special depth, since for a person "habit is second nature". His whole being is in the world of attachments, traditions, relies on the sensory, emotional sphere, which is based on basic attitudes. In the new reality, not only are new meanings and purpose of a person significant, but also their attitude to reality itself requires revision. The new picture of being requires a new vision of the world and oneself in it.

It should be noted here that the situation arose and is developing in the temporary conditions of a digital civilisation. At such a pace, characteristic of digital development, it is necessary to consider the issue of a possible revision of ideas about realisation in a profession as a basic value that determines both a person's self-esteem and his status in society.

The ethical aspect of this problem lies in the social responsibility of the state for what is happening and its consequences. The pace of digitalisation requires an energetic rethinking of existing concepts and ideas. However, the dialectical contradiction is that the speed of socio-technological changes in the era after a qualitative leap in the pace of development leads to a sharp narrowing of the horizons of scientific foresight, critically

increasing the risk and cost of an error in choosing decisions regarding plans for any development, including infrastructural, economic and military–industrial. The problem of personality formation itself is becoming especially acute, which includes not only the requirement to modernise the concepts of upbringing and education, but also a revision of fundamental ideas about the purpose of man and basic values, since their core idea of human selfhood—implementation in a profession already at the next stage of development of digital technologies and artificial intelligence—may prove untenable.

The social responsibility of the state, including the urgent task of a social philosopher, is seen in an attempt to rethink existing ideas about the purpose of man in relation to the new digital era. Therefore, it is, speaking in the most general sense, to try to build an ideal image of man corresponding to this new destiny; that is, a model of man adequate to the new reality of the digital world. At the same time, the new picture of being with all its details, like all concepts of personality formation adequate to the new reality, must be presented taking into account the extremely limited unpredictability of even the near future.

This is necessary, since an extremely vague picture of the technological future at such a pace is only one of the problems. More significant here are the questions that lie in the humanitarian plane: about the purpose of man, about what is good ("happiness"), about the responsibility of society for the results of socio-technological development; that is, the eternal questions that have carried out the transition to a digital civilisation and require an understanding of the energy that corresponds to the temporality of the digital world. The future itself depends on whether the answers will follow over time (that is, immediately) and what they will be, in the spirit of Wiener's philosophy, not only the spontaneous play of technical and economic forces (mechanistic principles such as "least action" or least free energy), but also the principles of humanism and ideas about the aspirations of the human spirit that have been developed over millennia, the future itself depends.

5. Conclusions

The results of this study show that in light of such rapid digital development [3], especially associated with the progress of generative artificial intelligence [16], the most important challenge is not so much the radical reduction of jobs [8,36,90] (in itself), but the associated loss of a profession as an existentially important component of human life. It is precisely that component of life that in recent decades has structured existence, provided motivation and, ultimately, the meaning of life [73].

5.1. Theoretical Conclusions

First, having considered the issue of the pace of digital progress in the context of sustainable development goals [2] in general and the development of the labour market in particular [27], we came to the conclusion about the categorical need for regulation in this area, especially in conditions where the pace of socio-technological transformations may exceed the adaptive capabilities of humans and society.

Second, it is noted that suddenly emerging conditions, when in a certain temporality of the digital world [1] there are transformations of the world of work [90] with an uncertain role of man, can be designated as an existential threat to the social organism, whose reaction to changes in the technological environment is significantly delayed.

5.2. Practical Conclusions

First, we believe that, despite the historical experience of spontaneous harmonisation of the stability of human relations with technologies [60], there must be a new ethic of social responsibility regulating human relations with intelligent machines and under any conditions determining the primacy of the social role of man.

Second, along with this, the inevitable reduction of the knowledge-intensive labour market exacerbates the problems and tasks of sustainable development [37,38,59]. The noted fact requires a revision of the understanding of labour as the main purpose of man, which has developed over the past several hundred years and is cultivated by all social

institutions, and, accordingly, the idea of realisation in a profession as a basic value that determines self-respect and status in society. This necessity requires the responsibility of the philosophical and sociological communities, requires their full involvement and enormous efforts.

5.3. Limitations and Suggestions for Further Development of This Study

This study is limited by theoretical and metaphysical considerations and is considered as a possible theoretical basis that sets the problematic field for future potential empirical studies. Thus, based on the obtained results, it can be said that further large-scale analysis of the problems that inevitably follow global digitalisation, which occurs against the backdrop of the powerful development of generative artificial intelligence, is necessary. This is an urgent task that requires an immediate solution.

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